

Uncovering history

Bal Krishen Thapar was born in Ludhiana and studied history at university. Having developed an interest in the discipline of archaeology, he joined the Indian School of Field Archaeology in 1944, where he trained under the British archaeologist Sir Mortimer Wheeler. Wheeler had pioneered the use of scientific techniques in the field, which Thapar would continue to rely on these during his long stint at the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI). Meticulous and single-minded, Thapar participated in several important excavations, including at the Somnath temple in Gujarat, the Harappan site of Kalibangan in Rajasthan and in Afghanistan. In 1978, he was appointed Director-General of the ASI.